Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary
Application Number: DM2025/01591
Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH
Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.
Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details
Name: Mr Abhinav Kant
Address: 9 Priory Crescent North Cheam SM3 8LR

Comment Details
Commenter Type:
Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application
Comment Reasons:
Comment:

FORMAL PLANNING OBJECTION

Application Reference: DM2025/01591
Site Address: Former Ambulance Station, Dorset Road, Belmont SM2 6JH

This representation is submitted on material planning grounds. It addresses the submitted Transport Statement, Fire Strategy and supporting documents, and demonstrates that the proposal fails to meet the statutory and policy requirements for approval.

1. National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) - Highway Safety and Severe Impact Test

Paragraph 115 of the National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) states:

Development should only be refused on highways grounds if there would be an unacceptable impact on highway safety, or the residual cumulative impacts on the road network would be severe.

The applicant asserts that objections are speculative. However, the applicant's own evidence confirms:

- On-site parking provision of 14 spaces, of which only 11 are available to attendees.
- Peak demand modelling of up to 80 vehicles during overlap periods.
- Maximum building capacity of 297 persons (Fire Strategy).
- Weekly peak congregation of approximately 200-250 attendees.

This results in approximately 69 vehicles (circa 86% of peak demand) reliant on surrounding residential streets.

Severity must be assessed in context, having regard to:
- Residential cul-de-sac typology,
- Limited turning geometry and egress routes,
- Proximity to Avenue Primary Academy (1,000+ pupils),
- Nearby event-based uses including Sutton Bowling Club and Downs Lawn Tennis Club.

The question is not whether total gridlock occurs, but whether predictable and repeatable peak congregation results in severe cumulative stress within this constrained local network. When assessed proportionately in this context, the NPPF threshold is engaged.

2. Misapplication of the "Lawful Fallback" Position

The applicant relies on historic 24-hour ambulance station use as a fallback baseline. This reliance is materially flawed.

(a) Realistic Prospect Test

Case law establishes that fallback carries weight only where there is a realistic and genuine prospect of implementation. No evidence has been provided that:
- The NHS or emergency authority intends to recommence operations,
- The building remains operationally configured for dispatch,
- Contracts or operational arrangements remain in place.

Absent such evidence, the fallback carries limited planning weight.

(b) Fundamental Operational Differences

Emergency dispatch characteristics:
- Controlled, trained drivers,
- Short dwell times,
- Dispersed trip patterns,
- Non-congregational use.

Proposed congregational use characteristics:
- Simultaneous arrival and departure,
- Concentrated dwell periods,
- Private vehicle dominance,
- Circulation and parking-search behaviour,
- Pedestrian clustering.

These are materially different transport typologies. Use of emergency dispatch as a comparator understates behavioural and parking implications associated with congregation-based land use.

(c) Intensity and Pattern

Even if fallback were realistic, assessment must consider pattern and intensity. A weekly 60-90 minute overlap window involving 200-250 attendees represents concentrated loading fundamentally different from historic dispatch operations.

3. Structural Overspill Identified in Applicant's Evidence

The Transport Statement confirms:
- 11 attendee parking spaces,
- Peak vehicle demand up to 80,
- 69 vehicles reliant on surrounding streets.

This is not marginal overflow; it is structural overspill.

Friday congregation is weekly, foreseeable and repeatable. Planning assessment must consider credible maximum utilisation, particularly where physical extension facilitates increased occupancy.

4. Inadequate Cumulative Impact Assessment

The submitted assessment does not properly model overlapping peaks with nearby event venues including:
- Sutton Bowling Club,
- Downs Lawn Tennis Club,
- Scheduled Friday evening events in the vicinity.

Cumulative impact assessment must evaluate overlapping time windows. Isolation of this proposal from the surrounding event ecosystem represents a methodological deficiency.

5. Cul-de-Sac Constraints and Network Resilience

Dorset Road and Balmoral Way exhibit:
- Limited turning geometry,
- Reliance on on-street parking,
- Absence of distributed egress routes,
- Direct driveway access along residential frontage.

In cul-de-sac typology, congestion risk arises from constrained manoeuvring space rather than high traffic volumes. Foreseeable consequences include:
- Multi-point turning,
- Reversing into pedestrian space,
- Parking search loops,
- Pavement overhang,
- Junction visibility impairment.

In proximity to Avenue Primary Academy, these effects are amplified. No Road Safety Audit has modelled dispersal behaviour within this specific street typology.

6. Residential Amenity - Late Evening Dispersal

Operation until 23:00 is acknowledged.

Residential amenity harm includes:
- Engine noise,
- Door closures,
- Conversational clustering,
- Idling emissions,
- Vehicle searching behaviour.

Weekly late-evening dispersal of 200+ attendees materially differs from incidental residential movements. The ambulance fallback comparison is not analogous.

7. Impact on Vulnerable Users

Overspill parking and circulation behaviour create disproportionate risk to:
- Elderly residents,
- Mobility-impaired individuals,
- Children walking from Avenue Primary Academy,
- Families with pushchairs.

These considerations engage both highway safety and residential amenity policies.

8. Absence of Secured Relocation Offset

The application assumes displacement from an existing venue. No condition or legal agreement secures:
- Permanent cessation of the existing use,
- Prevention of dual operation,
- Restriction of attendance below fire capacity.

Absent such safeguards, net trip intensification remains a credible risk.

9. Conditions Cannot Remedy Structural Capacity Deficit

Travel Plans and stewarding cannot:
- Create physical parking capacity,
- Prevent lawful on-street parking,
- Eliminate circulation behaviour,
- Remove cumulative overlap.

Where structural deficit exists (69 vehicles overspill at peak), conditions may mitigate but cannot neutralise impact.

CONCLUSION

When assessed objectively:
- Structural overspill parking is acknowledged by the applicant's own evidence.
- Peak congregation is weekly, predictable and repeatable.

- The site sits within a constrained residential cul-de-sac adjacent to a large primary school.
- The fallback comparison is legally weak and operationally incomparable.
- Cumulative modelling is incomplete.

Taken together, these factors demonstrate a credible risk of unacceptable highway safety impact and severe cumulative stress within the meaning of the National Planning Policy Framework.

The Local Planning Authority is respectfully requested to:

REFUSE planning permission on the grounds of unacceptable highway safety impact, severe cumulative parking stress, and material harm to residential amenity.